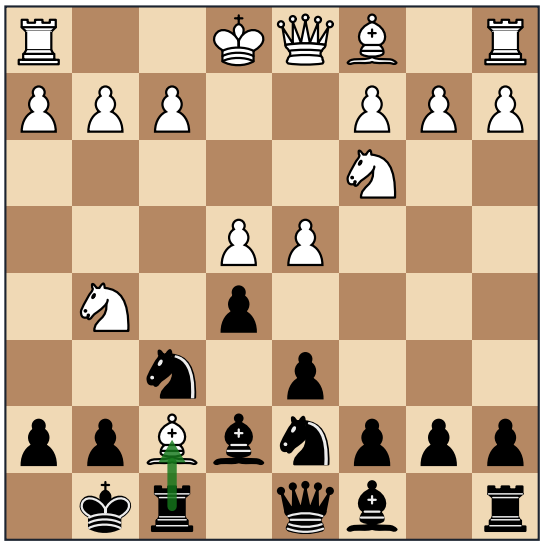
Philidor Defense

ECO C41 | 44 named lines | Semi-open / hypermodern defenses

In one sentence: Hypermodern and semi-open defenses avoid book fights: Black lets White build, then counterattacks the center.

Memory pattern: Let White build, then hit the center with ...c5 or ...e5.



Main line: 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nf6 4.Nc3 Nbd7 5.Bc4 Be7 6.Ng5 O-O 7.Bxf7

Key ideas

1. Black fianchettoes (Pirc/Modern) or hits e4 at once (Scandinavian, Alekhine).
2. White gets space and often a big center, but it can become a target.
3. Black's key breaks are ...c5, ...e5 and ...f5 at the right moment.
4. Develop quickly and avoid early queen moves unless they win time.
5. White should avoid overextension and keep pieces coordinated.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **-0.34** (slightly better for Black, depth 20). Best: Rxf7.

The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Black avoids symmetrical development: a fianchetto (Pirc/Modern), a quick ...d5 (Scandinavian) or tempo play (Alekhine). White often gets a big center.
2. Where does my king go?	Black castles short behind the fianchetto; White often attacks with f4/Be3/Qd2/h4.
3. Best minor pieces?	Black: Bg7, Nf6/Nd7, ...c5/...e5 breaks. White: Nc3, Nf3, Be3, Bc4.
4. Main middlegame plan?	Black waits, then undermines the center with ...c5 or ...e5; White consolidates the center and develops quickly.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants a big center and a fast attack; Black wants to hit the center in time.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nf6 4.Nc3 Nbd7 5.Bc4 Be7 6.Ng5 O-O 7.Bxf7

Move	Why it is played
1. e4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... e5	Challenge the center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
2. Nf3	Develops the knight to f3.
2... d6	Support. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
3. d4	Take the center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
3... Nf6	Hit e4. Develops the knight to f6.
4. Nc3	Develops the knight to c3.
4... Nbd7	Develops the knight to d7.
5. Bc4	Active bishop. Develops the bishop to c4.
5... Be7	Develops the bishop to e7.
6. Ng5	Repositions the knight to a more active square.
6... O-O	Castles: the king reaches safety and the rook joins the center.
7. Bxf7	Captures on f7 to trade or win material.



After 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6



After d6 3.d4 Nf6 4.Nc3 Nbd7

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.



Position after the line

Lion Variation C41 | 8 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nf6 4.Nc3 Nbd7`

Stockfish: **+0.52** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: Bc4.
What to look for: Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop); d4 (take the center)
Sub-variations: Lion's Claw, Bishop Sacrifice, Delayed Bishop Sacrifice, Forcing Line



Position after the line

Hanham Variation C41 | 6 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nd7`

Stockfish: **+0.59** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: Bc4.
What to look for: Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop); d4 (take the center)
Sub-variations: Delmar Variation, Krause Variation, Schlechter Variation, Sharp Variation



Position after the line

Nimzowitsch Variation C41 | 5 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nf6`

Stockfish: **+0.59** (slightly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: dxe5.
What to look for: Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop); d4 (take the center)
Sub-variations: Klein Variation, Rellstab Variation, Sokolsky Variation



Position after the line

Philidor Countergambit C41 | 4 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 f5`

Stockfish: **+1.70** (clearly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: Bc4.
What to look for: Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop); d4 (take the center)
Sub-variations: Berger Variation, Zukertort Variation, del Rio Attack

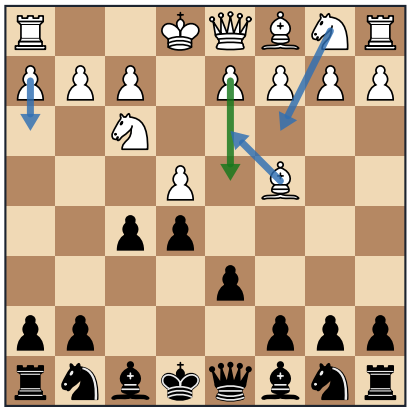


Position after the line

Exchange Variation C41 | 3 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 exd4`

Stockfish: **+0.65** (slightly better for White, depth 18). Best next move: Nxd4.
What to look for: Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop); d4 (take the center)



Position after the line

Lopez Countergambit C41 | 2 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.Bc4 f5`

Stockfish: **+1.67** (clearly better for White, depth 17). Best next move: d4.
What to look for: Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop); d4 (take the center)
Sub-variations: Jaenisch Variation

Expert and coach view

What a coach would tell you

Know the move-order tricks: in the Pirc, White's Austrian Attack (f4) is the main danger; in the Scandinavian, learn the queen retreat squares (a5, d6, d8). Always counterattack the center within the first 8-10 moves.

Why play it

Hypermodern and semi-open defenses avoid book fights: Black lets White build, then counterattacks the center.

Typical mistakes

- Letting White roll forward with e5 and f4 without a counter-break.
- Moving the queen repeatedly in the Scandinavian and falling behind in development.
- Fianchettoing without castling early and leaving the king exposed.

Typical tactics and traps

- Bxf7+ or Bxh7+ if Black's king sits behind a fianchetto without defenders.
- e5 forks or pins after Black ignores the center.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Black aims to undermine White's center and reach an equal middlegame with flexible pawn structure.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Philidor Defense (all lines)** — C41
  `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6`
  - **Exchange Variation** — C41
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 -> 3.d4 exd4`
  - **Hanham Variation** — C41
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 -> 3.d4 Nd7`
    - **Sharp Variation** — C41
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nd7 -> 4.Bc4 Nb6`
    - **Delmar Variation** — C41
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nd7 -> 4.Bc4 c6 5.c3`
    - **Krause Variation** — C41
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nd7 -> 4.Bc4 c6 5.O-O`
    - **Schlechter Variation** — C41
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nd7 -> 4.Bc4 c6 5.Nc3`
    - **Steiner Variation** — C41
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nd7 -> 4.Bc4 c6 5.O-O Be7 6.dxe5`
  - **Lopez Countergambit** — C41
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 -> 3.Bc4 f5`
    - **Jaenisch Variation** — C41
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 f5 4.Bc4 exd4 5.Ng5 Nh6 6.Nxh7`
  - **Nimzowitsch** — C41
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 -> 3.d4 Nf6`
    - **Locock Variation** — C41
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nf6 -> 4.Ng5`
    - **Larobok Variation** — C41
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nf6 -> 4.Nc3 Nbd7 5.Bc4 Be7 6.Ng5 O-O 7.Bxf7`
  - **Nimzowitsch Variation** — C41
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 -> 3.d4 Nf6`
    - **Klein Variation** — C41
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nf6 -> 4.Bc4`
    - **Rellstab Variation** — C41
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nf6 -> 4.dxe5 Nxe4 5.Qd5`
    - **Sokolsky Variation** — C41
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nf6 -> 4.dxe5 Nxe4 5.Nbd2`
  - **Philidor Countergambit** — C41
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 -> 3.d4 f5`
    - **Zukertort Variation** — C41
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 f5 -> 4.Nc3`
    - **del Rio Attack** — C41
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 f5 -> 4.dxe5 fxe4 5.Ng5 d5 6.e6`
    - **Berger Variation** — C41
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 f5 -> 4.dxe5 fxe4 5.Ng5 d5 6.e6 Bc5 7.Nc3`
  - **Philidor Gambit** — C41
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 -> 3.d4 Bd7`
  - **Bird Gambit** — C41
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 -> 3.d4 exd4 4.c3`
  - **Morphy Gambit** — C41
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 -> 3.d4 exd4 4.Bc4`
  - **Steinitz Variation** — C41
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 -> 3.Bc4 Be7 4.c3`
  - **Albin-Blackburne Gambit** — C41
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 -> 3.d4 Bg4 4.dxe5 Nd7`
  - **Boden Variation** — C41
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 -> 3.d4 exd4 4.Qxd4 Bd7`
  - **Larsen Variation** — C41
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 -> 3.d4 exd4 4.Nxd4 g6`
  - **Lion Variation** — C41
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 -> 3.d4 Nf6 4.Nc3 Nbd7`

- **Lion's Claw** C41
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nf6 4.Nc3 Nbd7
  - **with Bc4 and h6** C41
    1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nf6 4.Nc3 Nbd7 -> 5.Bc4 Be7 6.O-O h6
  - **with Be2 and c6** C41
    1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nf6 4.Nc3 Nbd7 -> 5.Be2 Be7 6.O-O c6
- **Shirov Gambit** C41
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nd7 4.Nc3 Ngf6 5.g4
- **Bishop Sacrifice** C41
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nf6 4.Nc3 Nbd7 -> 5.Bc4 Be7 6.Bxf7
- **Delayed Bishop Sacrifice** C41
  1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 Nbd7 4.Nf3 e5 5.Bc4 Be7 6.dxe5 dxe5 7.Bxf7
- **Forcing Line** C41
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nf6 4.Nc3 Nbd7 -> 5.Bc4 Be7 6.Ng5 O-O 7.Bxf7 Rxf7 8.Ne6
- **Sozin Variation** C41
  1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 e5 4.Nf3 Nbd7 5.Bc4 Be7 6.O-O O-O 7.Qe2 c6 8.a4 exd4

- **Hanham** C41
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 -> 3.d4 Nd7 4.Bc4 c6 5.Ng5
  - **Kmoch Variation** C41
    1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nd7 4.Bc4 c6 5.Ng5
- **Paulsen Attack** C41
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 -> 3.d4 exd4 4.Nxd4 d5 5.exd5
- **Berger Variation** C41
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 -> 3.d4 exd4 4.Nxd4 Nf6 5.Nc3 Be7 6.Be2 O-O 7.O-O c5 8.Nf3 Nc6 9.Bg5 Be6 10.Re1

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

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1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Nf6 4.Nc3 Nbd7 5.Bc4 Be7
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Plan chain

White	Nc3 -> Nf3 -> d4 -> Bd2 -> Bc4
Black	Nf6 -> g6 -> Bg7 -> d6 -> c6

Three rules to remember

1. Let White build, then hit the center with ...c5 or ...e5.

2. Black waits, then undermines the center with ...c5 or ...e5; White consolidates the center and develops quickly.

3. White wants a big center and a fast attack; Black wants to hit the center in time.

Pawn structure in one line

Black avoids symmetrical development: a fianchetto (Pirc/Modern), a quick ...d5 (Scandinavian) or tempo play (Alekhine). White often gets a big center.